



Creating recreational trails take time, cooperation from railroads



The entrance to the Beaver River Rails to Trails is located behind the running track at Geneva College in Beaver Falls.

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By David Taube dtaube@timesonline.com | Posted 1 hour ago

Developing a riverfront trail plan can be painstakingly slow as driving a spike into a rail with a sledgehammer.

Getting cooperation from railroad companies may be just as hard.

Just ask Thomas "Norm" Ely.

The Rochester Township manager found a riverfront trail plan last fall, but said he has had

significant difficulty getting any kind of response from railroad staff.

Ely said a person connected with the Ohio River Trail Council has tried for months to contact Norfolk Southern Corp. officials without success. Members of the local trail development group said railroads can create significant hurdles in acquiring property or obtaining access, such as right-of-ways.

Dave Pidgeon, company spokesman for Norfolk, said it has a general policy not to support recreational trails along active rail lines.

"It's a safety issue, and those tracks exist for a single purpose, and that's for the movement of freight," Pidgeon said.

However, Vincent Troia, executive chairman and CEO for the Ohio River Trail Council, said the group is not even close to reaching out to any railway companies in the area.

"In Beaver County, we haven't contacted any of the railroads yet, and it won't be for a long time before we get there," Troia said. "There are plenty (of) other places to build first."

The Ohio River Trail Council envisions a 41-mile path that predominantly runs along the Ohio and Beaver rivers, going through major areas such as Coraopolis, Sewickley, Ambridge, Monaca, Beaver and Midland. It will include feeder trails to areas like Beaver Falls.

The trail would connect with others, including one in Ohio and a leg of the Montour Trail in Moon Township, which will ultimately connect it with the Great Allegheny Passage, a trail that spans from the Pittsburgh area to Cumberland, Md.

But the council is still only six years into a 20- to 30-year project to develop the trail network, Troia said.

Jack Manning, a director for the council, said their maps have a proposed route, but as part of the planning process, several alternative routes can be made as organizers determine what's affordable and feasible.

Often, railroads are used as the last step in the process, Troia noted.

Todd Stevenson, secretary for the nonprofit Beaver River Rails to Trails, said his organization also faced stumbling blocks. He said one company that owned an abandoned railway bed in Beaver Falls wanted \$200,000 for 50 yards, so they dog-legged its route to create a trail in the city.

The roughly two-mile trail, completed four or five years ago, runs from First Avenue and 11th Street to the Geneva College area, said Karl Boak, a former president of the group.

In March, local trail advocates and officials met with CSX Transportation Inc. and the Pennsylvania Public Utility Commission to talk about opening a tunnel so the public could reach the Beaver River in Beaver Falls. Rubble currently blocks the tunnel, which used to give railroad passengers access to the city.

Access to the river in the Beaver Falls area is limited, so people cross the railroad to reach the

water, Stevenson said. If the request was part of a recreational path network, creating an off-shoot of the trail, that could help secure riverfront access, he said.

A foreman from the railroad was there, and he agreed with the proposal, but admitted someone in the company's Jacksonville, Fla.-headquarters would have to rubber-stamp the decision, Stevenson recalled. Councilman Doug Carson is pursuing the tunnel possibility.

In May, Geneva College engineering students gave a senior project presentation about opening the tunnel and creating a dedicated bike bridge into New Brighton, but the latter would cost millions, Stevenson said.

With the Ohio River Trail Council, the group has yet to secure any property in Beaver County, Manning said.

Troia said earlier this month, however, verbal agreements are in place with some property owners in Ohioville. They're just waiting to be signed, he said.

Meanwhile, Manning is eager for construction to start. For Troia, it's still early.

"We've made quite a lot of progress, but ... it takes time," Troia said.

Ohio River Trail fundraiser

An annual fundraiser for the Ohio River Trail Council will occur July 12 at Bradys Run Park, with all proceeds used to construct the recreational trail.

The "Gear & Cheer Music Festival" will feature 40 Weeks, The Olive Mountain Band, Blind Association, The East Enders, The Delaneys, Exempt, The Brighton Boys and Circle of One.

Vendors, kayaking, arts and crafts, stand-up paddling, canoeing and fishing will run from 10 a.m. to 6 p.m. Hiking will occur at 2 p.m.

Paid events range from a 5-kilometer walk/run at 9 a.m., road cycling at 9:30 a.m., mountain biking at 10 a.m., a kayak race at 1 p.m., a rock wall from 11 a.m. to 4 p.m.

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